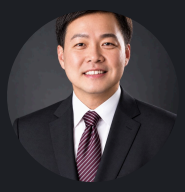
JASON CHOI
REAL ESTATE

FREE CHECKLIST

CONDO BUYER'S CHECKLIST

Condo & Strata Red Flags

The warning signs to look for in condo documents before you remove conditions — for buyers in Alberta (condominiums) and British Columbia (strata).



Jason Choi 최재봉

REALTOR® since 2007 · Licensed in Alberta & BC

First Place Realty (AB) · Maple Supreme Realty Inc. (BC)

(403) 399-8124 · CalgaryJason@gmail.com

jasonchoirealestate.com · English · 한국어

How to Use This Checklist

When you buy a condo, you also buy into the building's finances, repairs and rules. During your condition period, you, your REALTOR®, and a condo document reviewer or lawyer go through the condo documents. Use this checklist to spot problems **before** your deal becomes firm.

Level	What to do
● Serious	Get expert advice before going ahead. You may need to renegotiate the price or walk away.
● Investigate	Ask questions and get answers in writing before you remove conditions.
● Good to know	Not a deal-breaker, but factor it into your decision and budget.

● Serious Red Flags

☐	Warning sign	What it can mean for you
☐	**Reserve fund far below the recommended level** in the reserve fund study (AB) or depreciation report (BC)	A large special assessment (levy) is likely. Ask how big the shortfall is per unit.
☐	**A special assessment has been approved** but was not mentioned in the listing	In Alberta, unpaid amounts can stay with the unit. Confirm in writing who pays (often negotiated so the seller pays).
☐	**Lawsuits** involving the condo corporation	Legal costs and settlements can be passed on to all owners. Have a lawyer review the details.
☐	**Water leaks, mould or building envelope failure** (especially BC wood-frame buildings from about 1982–1998)	Repairs can cost tens of thousands of dollars per unit. Ask for engineering reports.
☐	**Major parts at the end of their life** (roof, parkade, elevator, boiler) with no money or plan to fix them	Expect higher fees or a special assessment soon.
☐	**Building insurance lapsed, cancelled** or under dispute	Your lender may refuse to fund the mortgage.
☐	**Many owners not paying their fees**	The building may not have enough money to operate.
☐	**Unapproved changes to common property** by the seller (walls removed, balcony enclosed)	You could be ordered to restore it at your cost.

If you find a serious red flag

Do not remove your conditions yet. Ask your REALTOR® to request more time if needed, and get advice from a condo lawyer, engineer or insurance professional. Sometimes the best decision is to walk away.

Investigate Before Removing Conditions

☐	Warning sign	What it can mean for you
☐	Reserve fund is somewhat underfunded	A special assessment is possible in the next few years. Ask if the board has a plan to catch up.
☐	A special assessment was voted on but not yet collected	Confirm the amount per unit, the payment dates and who pays at closing.
☐	Very high insurance deductible (common in BC: $25,000–$100,000+ for water damage)	If damage starts in your unit, you may owe the deductible. Buy condo insurance that covers it.
☐	Repeated water damage or mould claims in the minutes	There may be an ongoing building problem.
☐	Property manager changed 2+ times in 5 years	May point to money or management problems.
☐	Reserve fund study (AB) or depreciation report (BC) is out of date	Alberta requires a study at least every 5 years. BC stratas with 5+ units must get a depreciation report every 5 years and can no longer waive it. An old report hides future costs.
☐	Condo fees went up more than 10–15% in a year, or big increases are planned	Could mean rising insurance, catch-up repairs or a budget deficit.
☐	Bylaws limit rentals or short-term rentals (Airbnb)	A deal-breaker if you plan to rent the unit. Read the exact wording.

Good to Know

☐	Warning sign	What it can mean for you
☐	Age of major parts: roof (20–30 yrs), boiler/HVAC (15–25), elevator (20–30), parkade membrane (15–25), windows (20–30)	Compare with the reserve fund plan.
☐	Pet rules (type, size, number)	Make sure your pets are allowed.

☐	Parking and storage: titled, assigned, or common property	Assigned stalls can sometimes be reassigned by the board.
☐	Age-restricted building (55+)	Confirm you qualify.
☐	Nearby development or rezoning in the minutes	May affect views, noise or value.
☐	Disputes between owners and the board	Can slow down decisions.
☐	Operating budget runs a deficit every year	Fees may be too low and could rise.
☐	Older building (before about 1990)	Ask about aluminum wiring, asbestos and Poly-B plumbing.

Documents to Ask For

Alberta condominium	British Columbia strata
Estoppel certificate (recent)	Form B – Information Certificate (recent)
Reserve fund study, report and plan	Depreciation report
Registered bylaws and rules	Registered bylaws and rules
Current budget	Current budget
Financial statements (last 2 years)	Financial statements (last 2 years)
AGM minutes (last 2 years)	AGM minutes (last 2 years)
Board minutes (last 12–24 months)	Council minutes (last 12–24 months)
Insurance certificate	Insurance certificate and deductibles
Special assessment and litigation details	Special levy and litigation details
Condominium plan (unit boundaries)	Strata plan (unit, limited common property)
Move-in / move-out fees	Form F – Certificate of Payment (at completion)

Questions to Ask the Property Manager

- What is the reserve fund balance, and what does the latest study or report recommend?
- Are any special assessments approved, pending, or being discussed?
- Has the building had water leaks or envelope problems? What was repaired, and when?
- Are there any current or expected lawsuits?
- What is the insurance deductible, and when is the owner responsible for it?
- What are the rules on rentals, short-term rentals and pets?

- What major projects are planned in the next 2–3 years?
- What special assessments have there been in the last 10 years?

If You Find a Problem — Your Options

Option	How it works
Ask for a lower price	Estimate your share of likely future costs and negotiate it off the price.
Seller pays the special assessment	Write into the contract that the seller pays any approved levy in full at closing.
Get an expert report	Make your offer conditional on an engineering or building envelope report.
Ask for updated documents	If the estoppel certificate or Form B is old, ask for a current one.
Get legal advice	For lawsuits, major repairs or unclear bylaws, speak with a condo lawyer.
Walk away	Some buildings are not worth the risk at any price. It is better to lose a deal than inherit a big bill.

Buying a condo?
I review condo documents with my clients and help negotiate when problems come up. Call or text **(403) 399-8124**, email **CalgaryJason@gmail.com**, or visit **jasonchoirealestate.com**. English and 한국어.

This checklist is for general information only and is not legal, engineering, financial or insurance advice. Rules differ between Alberta and BC and can change. Always get independent advice from a condo/strata lawyer, condo document reviewer, engineer or insurance professional when you find a concern. Prepared by Jason Choi, REALTOR®, First Place Realty. Information believed accurate but not guaranteed. Updated November 2026.